A LEGACY OF CHAMPIONS

In 1919, as the United States emerged from World War I and entered an era of industrial and cultural transformation, the Feinbloom brothers founded Champion.

What began as a maker of collegiate sports uniforms soon expanded beyond the field, outfitting American troops in two world wars, Olympians at the height of competition, and generations of students, workers, and artists.

From the mouse to the moon, from Michael to MoMA, Champion has been woven into the very fabric of American history and culture.

1919

Knickerbocker Knitting Mills is founded in Rochester, NY.



1920



More than 8 million women champion democracy and vote in the U.S. election for the first time after the passage of the 19th Amendment.

1926



Champion Knitwear Mills, Inc. begins providing school uniforms to Wentworth Military Academy. This milestone set the foundation for Champion's enduring tradition of supporting collegiate teams.

1930

Champion began supplying college uniforms for major programs across the U.S.

For 91 years, every major men's and women's college sport was at one time outfitted in Champion uniforms.

1930's



Champion sponsors women's basketball leagues through its retail stores.

1931

The first Mickey Mouse licensed apparel is created via Champion's Norwich Knitting Mills.



1938



The iconic Reverse Weave sweatshirt is patented to minimize shrinkage.

1941

After the attack on Pearl Harbor in December, Champion supplied the military with T-shirts and sweatshirts featuring unit or base insignias as part of their uniforms throughout the war.





1952

An updated Reverse Weave® design with expansion gussets is patented.

1960

Champion Muhammad Ali wins gold in the light heavyweight division at the Summer Olympics in Rome.





1967

Champion debuts nylon mesh football uniforms, which were worn by SMU's football team in their season opener against Texas A&M.



1966

Champion Roberta "Bobbi" Gibb made history as the first woman to run the Boston Marathon, finishing in 3 hours and 21 minutes—beating half of her male competitors and defying the Boston Athletic Association's claim that women were "not physiologically able" to run more than 1.5 miles.

1968

Champion introduces Lady Champion, revolutionizing women's athletic wear with modern, mix-and-match PE uniforms and gym wear, while continuing its tradition of supporting female athletes with innovative products.



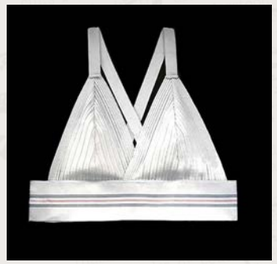
1969

Champion Neil Armstrong carries a Purdue banner made by Champion to the Moon.

1972

Title IX, a landmark federal law prohibiting sex discrimination in any education program or activity receiving federal financial assistance, is passed.





1977

Jogbra, the first women's sports bra, is invented by Hinda Miller, Lisa Lindahl, and Polly Palmer Smith.

1978

The Notre Dame basketball team is the first to wear the "C" logo on their uniforms—the first logo to ever appear on college uniforms in the United States.





1980's

Champion becomes the official outfitter of the U.S. Military Academy and collegiate sports teams.



1980's 1990's

Champion Reverse Weave became a staple among hip-hop artists, West Coast skaters, and NYC punks, serving as a canvas for self-expression.

1990

Champion becomes the exclusive outfitter for the NBA, providing jerseys for all teams throughout the 1990s.

1992-2001

Champion's jerseys were proudly worn by the first men's Dream Team, boosting global publicity. Champion outfitted all USA Basketball teams from 1989 to 2001, including the first women's Dream Team in 1996.



2017

The Champion Reverse Weave Hoodie, showcased in MoMA's Items: Is Fashion Modern? exhibit, was recognized for its cultural impact. In 2018, it became part of the museum's permanent collection.

2024

Authentic adds the originator of the sweatshirt to its growing portfolio, marking the company's second-largest acquisition. The move ushers in a new era for the iconic brand, reinforcing Authentic's commitment to preserving heritage while driving future growth in the fashion and lifestyle space.